According to tradition, the two epics are ‘itihasa’ or history. It is quite possible that that the central storylines, especially in the case of the Mahabharata, is loosely based on real events. However, in this book I am not concerned with the historical authenticity of the events described in the epics. My interest is in the expansion of geographical knowledge that we can discern from them.

The texts went through many changes over the centuries before they reached their current form, so one must not take all the information too literally. Nonetheless, in the understanding of the terrain there is a shift from the Vedic focus on the Sapta-Sindhu and neighbouring areas. Interestingly, the two epics have very different cardinal orientations. The geography of the Ramayana is oriented along a North–South axis while the Mahabharata is generally oriented on an East–West axis. This is not a total coincidence for they are aligned to two major trade routes. The Dakshina Path (or Southern Road) that made its way from the Gangetic plains though Central India to the southern tip of the peninsula while the Uttara Path (or Northern Road) that ran from eastern Afghanistan, through Punjab and the Gangetic plains, to the seaports of Bengal.